EWF Wrestling Manager

The road to A+

How to take every area of the game to the top grade: the first-month guide, story mode, the stat trim, a playtest plan, and a step-by-step order of work.

17 October 2026 | Version 0.85 | Follows: The game today (review) and Next week (plan)

Where we are, where we are going

Area	Now	Goal	The one thing that moves it most
Depth of the simulation	A	A+	Story mode: give the depth a ten-year spine.
Testing	A-	A+	Every suite green on both worlds, and the guide and story mode tested end to end.
Stability	B	A+	Fix Suggest a card in the parody world.
Code health	B	A+	Shorter lines and fewer wraps, a little each week.
Content and legal	B	A+	A licence, a clean history and a final legal check.
Screens and readability	B-	A+	The stat trim and a readability pass on every page.
Balance	C+	A+	Clear targets per company model, checked by a test on every build.
Learning the game	C	A+	The first-month guide, built from owner's tasks.
Ready for Steam	C	A+	Desktop saves, achievements, store page, and the wrapper in the tests.

The order of work

One step at a time, each shown to Ryan before the next (rule 9a). Each phase leaves the game better on its own.

Phase 1 Fix	Suggest a card in the parody world. The two failing tests (test-cancel, test-events). Fix the wording "the odds decide who wins".
Phase 2 Clear	The stat trim on screen. A readability pass on every one-screen page. Ryan picks the new desk look and the 1080p approach.
Phase 3 Watch	The first-hour playtest with five new players (plan below). Fix the top problems it finds.
Phase 4 Teach	The first-month guide, built as chapter 1 of story mode.

Phase 5 Grow	Story mode, one year at a time. The add-ons run (Phases 3 and 4) alongside.
Phase 6 Ship	Balance targets, Steam groundwork, a licence, the legal check.

How to reach A+ in every area

Learning the game — C to A+

A+ looks like: a new player books a good first show without opening Help, and by the end of month one can explain heat, the road and the gorilla position in their own words.

- The first-month guide, taught through owner's tasks (section below).
- A switch at the start: on and recommended for a first game, off by default once a save exists.
- Words before numbers everywhere: "Hot", "Worn down", "Strong market".
- Remove short forms from the bottom line (BP and AP become "Booking power" and "Action points" once, then the short forms with a note on hover and focus).
- F1 Help becomes "Ask the Timekeeper": search a word, get one paragraph and a button that takes you there.

How we will know: 4 of 5 playtesters finish week 1 without asking for help; nobody quits in the first 20 minutes.

Screens and readability — B- to A+

A+ looks like: every page reads at arm's length on a TV, nothing is cut off, every colour has a word beside it, and the eye lands on what matters first.

- The stat trim (section below): six meters a wrestler, not fifteen.
- One type scale and one button style in the window kit, set once.
- No cut-off lines: a check added to `fits()` that fails on any text ending in "...".
- Empty states that tell you what to do: the empty run sheet says "Press Suggest a card to start, then change what you like", with that button the biggest on the page.
- Use the room at 1080p: 20 roster rows instead of 15, no empty bands, the safe-area border only on a TV.
- Run the accessibility review on each page: contrast, colour plus word, keyboard and pad focus.

How we will know: zero cut-off lines in the test suite; every page passes contrast; playtesters find the next action in under 5 seconds.

Stability — B to A+

A+ looks like: every company in every world can play ten years on suggested cards with no invalid card, no error and no bad number.

- Fix Suggest a card for brand shows in the parody world (EWE, AYY, CALL, ARK fail between weeks 48 and 60).
- Make test-uni run both worlds for 240 weeks (5 years) in the full suite, not 60.
- A save from every earlier version loads: keep a folder of old saves and a test that loads each.

How we will know: test-uni green on both worlds at 240 weeks; the old-saves test green.

Balance — C+ to A+

A+ looks like: every company is hard in its own way and fair. A good booker always beats Suggest a card; Suggest a card never gets you fired in year one.

- Write targets per model into a test (tools/balance.js already measures them): cash growth, owner trust, weeks survived, crowd against expectation.
- The giant: fired on 2 of 3 seeds. Soften the owner's reaction to middling shows for big companies.
- The workrate and outlaw companies: the two that go broke. Look at their costs against their crowds.
- The startup: too easy once it gets a better slot. Scale the slot's money to the company's size.
- Story mode chapters each get their own target, tested the same way.

How we will know: the balance test passes on 5 seeds for all nine models, every build.

Depth of the simulation — A to A+

A+ looks like: the depth is felt, not just present. Every system shows up in a story the player remembers.

- Story mode gives the systems a reason: a TV deal chapter makes networks matter, a war chapter makes invasions matter.
- A cap on interruptions: rank matters and calls by weight, show the top three a week, let the rest wait or resolve on their own.
- Finish the add-ons run: supercards, academy, dynasties, the match viewer, sound.
- A "how did that happen" line on every result: the post-mortem's chain of causes, one press away.

How we will know: playtesters retell a story from their game ("my champion walked out and I...").

Testing — A- to A+

A+ looks like: every suite green, every new system tested headless and in the browser, and a test for every guide lesson and story chapter.

- Green before anything else: the two failing tests first.
- A one-command full run (npm run test:all) with a summary at the end.
- test-guide.js: a month with the guide on, every lesson fires once and in order. test-story.js: ten years on each chapter's targets.
- Browser: the first week walked with the guide; the cut-off check; the old-saves load.

Code health — B to A+

A+ looks like: a new contributor can find and change a system in an hour.

- Break lines longer than 160 characters whenever a file is touched anyway. No big rewrite.
- When a system wraps a function for the third time, add a proper hook instead.
- Split files over 500 lines (82-wishes.js, 10-match.js) by topic.
- Keep docs/map.md and CLAUDE.md current with each change.

Content and legal — B to A+

A+ looks like: safe to sell, safe to mod.

- Pick a licence: the code all rights reserved, with a permissive licence for world packages so modders can share.
- Decide on rewriting git history to remove the old parody notes.
- A final lawyer's read of the parody world and the disclaimer.
- Story mode writing checked against rule 3 (original content).

Ready for Steam — C to A+

A+ looks like: installs, saves, and feels like a finished PC game.

- Saves as files the player can see, copy and back up, plus Steam Cloud.
- Achievements tied to story beats and career moments (first sell-out, ten-year champion, won a war).
- The desktop wrapper built and smoke-tested in the test runs.
- Store page: screenshots from the new look, a short trailer from the match viewer, the parody disclaimer.
- Credits and a licence screen.

The first-month guide

> **The idea:** the game teaches through jobs, not lectures. The owner gives you a task; the guide walks you through doing it; the owner remembers whether you delivered.

The character: the Timekeeper

The old bell-ringer who has worked every show since 1971. On screen he is the ring bell from the dot-matrix lights (already drawn in the game). The bell rings when he wants your attention. He is original (rule 3), dry, kind, and brief.

- He always points at a real button: a highlight and one or two sentences.
- One tip at a time; the next waits until you have done the thing.
- He never holds up the SPACE key except for the required first actions.
- "Not now" on every tip. "Turn the guide off" in Options.
- He retires at the end of month one, then answers F1 as "Ask the Timekeeper", and comes back once for each brand-new thing.

The switch when a game starts

Element	Copy
Switch label	**First-month guide**
Under it	The Timekeeper walks you through your first four weeks: booking, the show, people and stories. Recommended for your first game.
Choices	**Guide me** / **I've booked before**
Default	Guide me when no save exists; I've booked before otherwise.

Four weeks, four owner's tasks

Week	The owner's task	What the guide walks you through	Hands on to
1 Opening night	"Put on a show this crowd will talk about."	Pick your announcers. Suggest a card, change one match. The show clock. On the air: the first call ("They're not going home"). After the show: the letter grade against this crowd.	A sponsor offer.
2 New blood	"Sign a new wrestler and make the crowd care."	Free agents: read a wrestler in words. The offer: wage, length, clauses. Book a debut: vignettes, a surprise attack or a straight match. After the show: did the crowd take to them?	A veteran jealous of the new signing.
3 People and stories	"Give me a story I'd pay to see."	Someone at your door. An action point spent backstage. Pick the year's storyline arc. Start a feud from Stories waiting. Heat and freshness. A promo for the feud. On the air: "Somebody is hurt".	The first big event, and no face of the company yet.

4 The big night	"Name the face of this company and sell me the big event."	Name the face. Plan a feud's ending for the big night. Three hours on the air, the owner on the headset wanting his favourite. The month in review: what went well and why.	Story mode's year one, or the sandbox.

Sample tips

> **The Timekeeper:** Forty years I've rung that bell. Here's the first rule: the owner pays the bills. Read his letter, then we'll get you on the air. *[Read the letter]*

> **The Timekeeper:** Two hours to fill and nothing on the sheet. Press Suggest a card. Then change one match you don't like. Nobody books it perfect first time. *[Suggest a card]*

> **The Timekeeper:** That B means you gave this crowd what they came for. Beat what they expect and you get an A. Same match in a cold town, different grade. *[Got it]*

> **The Timekeeper:** The boss wants new blood. Free agents is where they wait. Don't hunt for the best number. Look for somebody who suits how you book. *[Open free agents]*

> **The Timekeeper:** Signing them is half of it. Now make the crowd care: a few weeks of vignettes, or a surprise attack on somebody they already know. *[Book a debut]*

Copy rules: one idea per tip, under 40 words, every button names exactly what happens, the same words as the screens ("booking power", "the run sheet").

Story mode: ten years, one beat a year

> **Built as beats, not scenes.** Each chapter is an owner's goal, a turning-point event, and a pass or fail result, written in the existing scenario format. The beat adapts to your game: "your biggest star is unhappy" picks whoever really is your biggest star, and how you treated them sets how hard it gets. The first-month guide is chapter 1, month 1. Sandbox players turn it off and keep the same game.

Year	Chapter	Turning point	The owner's goal
1	The new booker	Your first month, with the guide	Finish the year with the owner's trust
2	Make a star	A raw signing with something special	Build a new main eventer
3	The TV deal	Your deal is up and a rival wants your slot	Win the renewal or a better network
4	Walkout	Your biggest star is unhappy and a rival is calling	Keep them, or replace them before the flagship
5	Stadium show	The owner books a stadium for the flagship	Sell it out
6	War	A rival invades	Win the war, or lose a year
7	New owner	The company is sold; the new owner doubts you	Win over the new boss
8	The old guard	Your veterans are fading	Pass the torch without losing the crowd
9	Number one	The biggest company is within reach	Top the world in popularity
10	Legacy	A retirement match for the face of your first decade	Send a legend out right; judged on the whole career

- **Failing a chapter** does not end the game: the next chapter starts harder (a weaker hand, a less patient owner). Only losing the owner's trust ends it.
- **Built from parts that exist:** scenarios as data, company arcs, owner goals and letters, invasions, network renewals, big events, career saves.
- **Achievements** come from it naturally: one per chapter, plus career moments.
- **Each year** goes to Ryan for a go-ahead before the next is written.

The stat trim

Counted from the code: how often each stat is used by the engine and on the screens. Change the screens first and leave the engine alone, so matches, balance and saves do not change.

Stat	Engine / screens	What to do
Fit (Free agents)	1 / 1 column	**Cut the number.** The road agent says "Suits how you book" or "Won't suit your style".
Loyalty	2 / 0	**Cut.** It does almost nothing.

Charisma and mic	27, 110 / 1, 5	**Merge** into "On the mic".
Brawling, technical, speed, stamina	18 to 27 / about 1	**Hide.** Show a style word and Work rate.
Hardcore	14 / 8	**A tag**, not a number.
Durability, safety, consistency	4 to 11 / 0	**Fold** into a hidden ring risk, felt through Body and the agent.
Star quality	18 / 0	**Fold** into Crowd.
Momentum	180 / 3	**Show as a word**: Hot, Cold, Steady.
Stress	30 / 12	**Fold into Mood** ("on edge").
Potential	53 / 2	**Words, once scouted**: "could be a main eventer".

> **The wrestler card after the trim:** Crowd, Work rate, On the mic, Mood, Body, a style word, momentum in a word, and the deal. Six meters instead of about fifteen. At company level the bottom line keeps cash, popularity and the owner; the rest are said in words where they appear.

The first-hour playtest

> **Goal:** find exactly where new players get lost, before the guide is written, so the guide teaches what people really miss.

Part	Plan
Method	Usability test, watched, no help given. Think aloud. Screen and voice recorded.
Who	5 players: 2 who know wrestling and management games, 2 who know wrestling only, 1 who knows management games only. None has seen the game.
Length	60 minutes each: 5 warm-up, 45 playing, 10 talk afterwards.
Tasks	1. Start a game. 2. Book and run your first show. 3. Answer what is on your desk. 4. Make one wrestler happier. 5. Start a storyline. Then play freely.
Watch for	Where they hesitate over 10 seconds. What they click that does nothing. Words they ask about. When they first smile. Whether they want to play another week.
Ask afterwards	What was the game about? What was confusing? What would you do next week? What did you ignore? Would you buy it?
Make sense of it	Put every observation on a card. Group them by theme (affinity map). Rank by how many players hit it and how hard it is to fix. The top five become the guide's lessons and the first fixes.
Done in	About a week: two days to find players, two days of sessions, one day to sort and report.

Decisions for Ryan

1. The guide character: the Timekeeper, the road agent, or another idea?
2. The first-month guide, on and recommended for a first game: yes?
3. Story mode: ten years, beats not scenes, one year at a time: yes?
4. The stat trim on screen first, engine untouched: yes?
5. Run the first-hour playtest before building the guide: yes?
6. The desk look, and design at 1080p while keeping 1280×720 working?
7. A cap on interruptions a week: how many?
8. The licence, and whether to rewrite git history for the old parody notes.

Built with the frontend-design, user-research and UX-copy skills, on top of the review "The game today" (docs/plans/EWF-game-review.pdf). Stat counts come from the code at version 0.85.